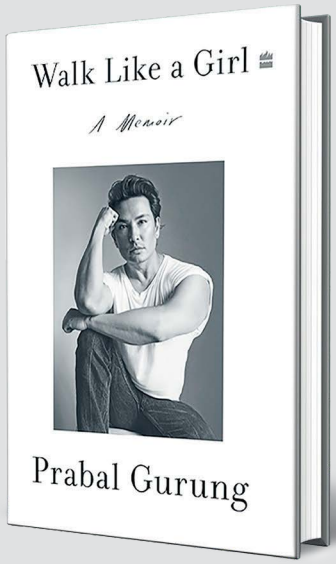


WALK LIKE A GIRL: A Memoir
By Prabal Gurung
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹799; 320 pages

For decades, the Nepali-American designer Prabal Gurung carried stories of personal struggle within him. Stories of assault and loss, bullying and taunts. As a globally renowned fashion designer, the most familiar mode of self-expression was through "fabric, through colour, silhouette, and craft.... But there were stories that clothes could not hold. Stories about fear. About longing. About shame. About survival," he says, in an email interview, of his memoir *Walk Like a Girl*. "I wrote this memoir now because I felt ready to examine my life with honesty and compassion. I have spent decades building a fashion house, but before that, I was a child growing up in South Asia, shaped by complex histories, expectations, and dreams. I wanted to trace that journey fully."

> THE MEMOIR IS REMARKABLY CANDID, LUCIDLY WRITTEN AND **INSIGHTFUL ABOUT LIFE AS AN IMMIGRANT AND QUEER SOUTH ASIAN,** AS ALSO ABOUT THE WIDER WORLD OF FASHION

Walk Like a Girl does just that, tracing his arc from Nepal to the US, from obscurity to the top of the fashion world, from self-doubt to self-realisation. It's remarkably candid, lucidly written and insightful about life as an immigrant and queer South Asian, as also about the wider world of fashion.

Gurung worked for major designers in the US before launching his own label in 2009. He first shot to global fame in 2010 when First Lady Michelle Obama wore a red dress he designed to an official event. Since then, his clothes have been worn by Oprah Winfrey, Sarah Jessica Parker and Katy Perry.

The memoir revisits some difficult experiences, including life as a misfit, episodes of unsettled family life, rape by an authority figure, assaults by peers and classmates. Some details were "extraordinarily difficult" to revisit. "There were days I had to stop writing because my body remembered before my mind did," he says. "Trauma does not disappear; it waits quietly in the corners. Revisiting those experiences meant revisiting the confusion and loneliness of a child who did not yet have the language for what was happening."

Gurung, who grew up in Nepal, was born into relative privilege. But his sexuality marked him out at an early age. After studying in Kathmandu and Delhi, Gurung enrolled at the Parsons School of Design in New York. In 1999, full of idealism and excitement, he arrived in the US, only to receive a rude shock. "America represented opportunity and reinvention. In some ways, I believed that talent and hard work would be enough," he says. Slurs like 'gaysian', or 'smelling like curry' were casually tossed around; there were often undercurrents of hostility at work. "The reality was more complicated.... There were moments of racism and homophobia that were jarring, especially as someone who had already navigated feeling different while growing up," he says.

Gurung writes of transforming that sense of being different, of being effeminate—which lends the book its